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Common medication-related questions for diarrheal treatment in Rwanda



June 2025

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Introduction

This report aims to answer commonly asked questions by medical practitioners of Rwanda, in terms of the four medication recommendations (Oral Rehydration Therapy, Zinc, Vitamin A, Probiotics) provided to treat emerging diarrheal diseases across the local region.

Question #1

: Can the Oral Rehydration Therapy (ORT) be mixed with solutions apart from water, such as tea or milk? What if I cannot attain clean water?

- No, ORT should only be mixed water to maximize its effectiveness. Mixing with any other liquid solutions could interfere with its electrolyte balance, greatly hindering the effectiveness of the treatment.
- In case of the unavailability of clean water, try to use boiled water if available, minimizing bacteria within it.

Question #2

: Can I use the recommended treatments for all types of diarrhea, specifically blood in stool?

- In the case of blood in stool or high fever, you should seek immediate medical help; Though the recommended treatments would not exacerbate your symptom, they would be ineffective as blood in stool indicates a much more serious infection.

Question #3

: Can I use the recommended treatments even during pregnancy or breastfeeding?

- All treatments are generally safe. However, while ORT and zinc supplements are completely safe for pregnant and breastfeeding women to use, vitamin A, as well as probiotics, should be taken with guidance from a healthcare provider, as excessive intakes could cause harm during pregnancy.

Question #4

: Can specific remedies be used along with the recommended treatments for maximum effectiveness?

- Some local remedies, such as porridge or light soup, can help keep patients nourished. However, avoid using herbal or unknown mixtures that may interact with medications to reduce their effectiveness. It is better to use the treatments individually, rather than through a combination of remedies.

Question #5

: How long should I be taking the treatments? When should I stop?

- The period of time needed to take each treatment depends on each. Take a look below for further information:
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- ORS: Stop when diarrhea stops and the patient is well-hydrated.
- Zinc: Complete 10 to 14 days, even if diarrhea improves earlier.
- Vitamin A: Only a single dose.
- Probiotics: Finish the 7-day course unless discomfort continues.

Question #6

: What should I do if the treatments show no impact?

- If there are no improvements after the treatments, and symptoms such as vomiting, high fever, blood in stool, or weakness appear, go to the nearest health center. Delay in treatment may lead to severe dehydration or complications.

Question #7

: Can I share leftover treatments with others?

- No, the treatments should not be shared with others. Each patient needs his/her right dosage based on age and condition.

Question #8

: How do I acknowledge that the treatments have gone bad?

- Primarily, one should always be aware of the expiration date for each treatment, labelled on the packet. If ORT or capsules have changed texture, color, or smell, they should be in disposal.

End of Report

If there are further medication-related questions, please click the document below or make contact via email.

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